

**From “Problem Student” to Contextual Learner:
Deconstructing Bias Toward Neurodivergent and CLD Students
Through Practicum Observation**

Piter García
University of Regina

Deconstructing Bias — Reflective Paper

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From “Problem Student” to Contextual Learner: Deconstructing Bias Toward Neurodivergent and CLD Students Through Practicum Observation

This paper examines a bias I have carried into classroom practice: the tendency to interpret neurodivergent and culturally/linguistically diverse (CLD) students through a compliance-and-deficit lens. In my practicum, that bias can show up as an automatic story: if a student is loud, impulsive, emotionally escalated, or “not listening,” they must be choosing to be disrespectful or disruptive. For this assignment, I analyze in-person classroom interactions from my elementary practicum placement during spring 2026 using time-stamped, verbatim observation records from lessons and mentor feedback conversations, alongside one course seminar discussion on linguistic justice. I label these materials as Evidence Sets E1–E4 and catalog them in `artifacts/evidence_index.md`.

The specific bias under investigation is the “problem student” stereotype as it attaches to difference: difference in regulation (often read through disability/neurodivergence) and difference in language/discourse (often read through culture and linguistic background). My guiding question is: **How do my practicum observations of neurodivergent and CLD students—especially students positioned as “problematic”—challenge the stereotype that disruption is a fixed trait, and what changes when adults respond relationally rather than punitively?**

My central claim is that what gets labeled “behavior” is often communication: a contextual response to unclear expectations, cognitive overload, linguistic mismatch, or unmet regulation needs. When the conditions shift—through relationship, co-regulation, and more linguistically just participation norms—students’ engagement shifts, revealing competence and brilliance that deficit stories erase.

Autobiographical Grounding: Naming the Bias

This paper is not written from a neutral position. I am writing as a student teacher who is simultaneously learning classroom management and learning to question the interpretive habits I bring into that work. The bias I am examining is not only something I have observed in others; it is a habit of interpretation that I recognize in my own instincts and that I need to examine honestly.

Talusan (2022) describes identity-conscious practice as the ongoing work of noticing which assumptions we carry and how they shape what we see in students—not a one-time confrontation but a repeatable discipline. That framing captures something true about my starting point. The stereotype I am interrogating—that certain students are naturally disruptive, lazy, or unmotivated—is not a belief I hold consciously. It is a reflex shaped by years of schooling in which compliance read as competence and visible struggle read as character deficit.

I grew up in a context where compliance read as competence: sitting still, quiet voices, fast processing, and Standard English were treated as the default markers of being a “good student.” Students whose learning looked different—talking while thinking, moving, needing repetition, using non-standard dialects, or taking longer to process directions—were subtly positioned as problems to manage. Those norms formed my instincts even when my values say otherwise.

Part of why I am drawn to examining behavioral stereotypes specifically is that I have already caught myself, more than once, having a first instinctive reaction to a student’s behavior before I have asked what is underneath it. This is the kind of socially learned bias that is easy to carry invisibly into the classroom—not out of malice, but out of the way schooling conditions us to read behavior. Naming it is the first step toward not reproducing it.

Observation Context

The observational material for this paper comes from my elementary school practicum placement in spring 2026. I draw on time-stamped, verbatim observation records created while I was present as a student teacher inside the instructional space. In the paper, I cite these materials as Evidence Sets E1–E4; the accompanying artifact index ([artifacts/evidence_index.md](#)) provides the source files, excerpt line references, and a crosswalk to where each excerpt is used.

The primary focal setting is Evidence Set E1: a grade 5 media/technology lesson (March 3, 2026) in which students learned to create short GIF videos on their Chromebooks. During this lesson, a focal student (pseudonym *Student M*) was repeatedly framed through a behavioral deficit narrative (“screaming,” “yelling”), while adults alternated between public compliance demands and more relational de-escalation moves (e.g., offering responsibility and negotiated incentives).

I also draw on Evidence Set E2: a grade 2 robotics/routines block (February 26, 2026) in which an adult explicitly named one student's behavior as "ruining this for your whole class" and "doing weird stuff," and then later repositioned that student as competent and helpful ("You're smart, you can help them").

Finally, I use Evidence Set E3: a mentor feedback conversation (April 8, 2026) in which my mentor discussed how relational connection and patience changed what was possible for *Student M* across the school day.

Course content also informs my interpretation. Evidence Set E4 is an EDU 442 seminar discussion on linguistic justice (March 9, 2026) in which we named how dominant language and discourse norms shape what counts as "respect" and "participation" in schools. I use that discussion to think about how CLD students can be misread when schools treat silence, speed, and standardized speech as the only legitimate way to learn.

Ethically, all student identifiers are removed. Student names in quoted excerpts are replaced with pseudonyms in square brackets. Ellipses (. . .) indicate omitted words for brevity; quoted phrasing otherwise preserves the original wording and disfluencies of spoken talk. Because Evidence Sets E1–E4 are unpublished practicum/course observation materials, they are cited in-text but not included in the References list.

Myth vs. Reality: Core Analysis

The myth. Neurodivergent and culturally/linguistically diverse (CLD) students become "problem students" because they are naturally disruptive, disrespectful, or unwilling to learn. In practice, this myth is sustained by two linked assumptions: (1) that silence and compliance equal learning, and (2) that deviation from dominant behavioral and linguistic norms signals character deficit.

DisCrit (Annamma et al., 2013) helps name why this is not a neutral mistake: disability and race are co-constructed in schooling, and labels like "disruptive" function as sorting technologies that shape students' trajectories. Flynn's (2024) affirmative non-tragedy model extends this critique

by arguing that deficit framings of difference treat disability as tragedy and respond with control instead of support.

Linguistic bias is part of the same apparatus. In a course seminar discussion on linguistic justice (E4), we named that schools “enact linguistic violence on students all the time” when they force students to speak and write in dominant ways without recognizing the histories behind those demands.

The reality. Across my practicum observation records (E1–E3), the “problem student” category is produced moment-by-moment through adult talk, task design, and relationship. In a grade 5 media lesson (E1), one adult issued public compliance commands (“Put your head down, [Student M]”) and another framed compliance as non-negotiable (“Put your head down. Why? Because I said so”). Those moves position the student’s body and voice as the problem to be suppressed.

But the same observation record captures a different set of moves that changed what was possible. A second adult invited the student into a purposeful role (“I need you to help me with the kids. Go! Go! Can you help me?”) and used negotiated, concrete reinforcement rather than shame: “So, if you don’t scream in the class, I’m gonna give you a keychain with a flashlight”; minutes later, the adult narrated competence: “So [Student M] is gonna get a keychain and a flashlight, because because you are doing amazing at your work” (E1). The student was not treated as a disruption to remove but as a person to bring back into the learning community.

At the end of the session, adult reflection revealed what the deficit narrative hides: “I’m actually so surprised how how smart he is” and “The fact that I got him to help me with others, I’m like shocked. It’s like a small improvement every time” (E1). In other words, the problem was not capacity. It was regulation and context.

That relational context appears even more clearly in a subsequent mentor feedback conversation. My mentor told me, “The amount of patience that you show with [Student M] is remarkable . . . you’ve created a connection with that kid . . . he lasers in on you . . . That was the best part of his morning . . . He’s used to people just yelling at him all day”; in the same conversation,

I explained the behavior in terms of triggers and control rather than willfulness: “he’s trying to control something that he cannot control. It just triggers him” (E3). This reframes “disruption” as a predictable response to chronic escalation and unmet regulation needs—and reframes pedagogy as co-regulation and trust-building.

The CLD dimension of this myth matters because the same compliance expectations that punish neurodivergence also punish cultural and linguistic difference. A classmate in our linguistic justice seminar noted that the “demand for total silence and compliance” is not universal; in many communities it is “normal, expected and good” to engage in dialogue as part of learning, yet students who speak out of turn can be punished and perceived as disrespectful (E4). When schooling treats dominant discourse norms as the only legitimate way to participate, CLD students are especially vulnerable to being read as “off-task” or “defiant” when they are, in fact, meaning-making. The practicum evidence sets show what happens when the adult response shifts from control to learning: participation becomes possible again.

Assets and Funds of Knowledge

An asset-based reading of the same observations reveals what the “problem student” story erases. Gonzalez, Moll, and Amanti’s (2005) funds of knowledge framework names this directly: students carry rich experiential resources from home, community, and lived experience that schools often fail to recognize. In a technology/STEM context, those funds can include troubleshooting habits, pattern recognition, storytelling, peer collaboration, and persistence.

In the grade 5 media lesson, adults named *Student M* as “screaming” and disrupting, yet Evidence Set E1 also contains the evidence of competence that deficit framings miss. One adult reflected, “I’m actually so surprised how how smart he is,” and emphasized that small gains mattered: “The fact that I got him to help me with others, I’m like shocked. It’s like a small improvement every time” (E1). When the student was positioned as a helper rather than a problem, he could participate in a pro-social way.

In the grade 2 robotics/routines block, the same repositioning occurred in real time. After a public correction, an adult later said, “You’re there? Why don’t you help your classmates? They’re

all struggling. You're smart, you can help them" (E2). This move treats competence and belonging as the starting point and invites the student into a classroom role with purpose.

Evidence Set E2 also contains explicit, asset-based language that centers cognitive diversity: "There's never just one way to solve a problem when you're coding. There's always multiple ways to figure it out, and the way that you guys think differently is a strength" (E2). This kind of talk does not "ignore behavior"; it names neurodivergent brilliance as real and worth organizing a classroom around.

For CLD students, assets are also linguistic. In our linguistic justice seminar, I argued that one equitable move in computer science is to invite students to "explain certain aspect of coding in their own language" (E4). Paris and Alim's (2014) culturally sustaining pedagogy helps me see why this matters: when schooling treats only one language variety and one participation style as legitimate, it erases students' communicative strengths. Linguistically just practice does not abandon academic language; it refuses the idea that students' home language, dialect, or discourse norms are deficits.

hooks (1994) calls this engaged pedagogy: staying curious about the whole person underneath the behavior and treating students as agents rather than objects to be managed. Across these observations, the assets were not hidden; they were made visible (or invisible) by how adults interpreted and responded.

Implications for Future Practice

These observations change what I want to do before I assign a label to a student. Talusan (2022) argues that identity-conscious practice is built from repeatable habits—not grand gestures, but daily routines of noticing and questioning. My commitments going forward begin with an interpretive pause.

First, I want to treat escalation as information, not defiance. When I notice a student yelling, shut down, or talking out of turn, my first questions should be contextual: what is the student trying to communicate? What is the trigger? What demand is too high right now (cognitive, social, sensory, or linguistic)? What support would make participation possible in the next two minutes? This is

aligned with Flynn’s (2024) affirmative orientation: difficulty is real, but the response should be support and dignity rather than tragedy and control.

Second, I want to lead with relationship and co-regulation. My mentor’s feedback that a student was “used to people just yelling at him all day” and that connection made a difference (E3) is a practical reminder that regulation is relational. In the grade 5 lesson, giving a student a pro-social role (helping others) and narrating competence supported re-entry into learning (E1). Those moves are not “extra”; they are part of instruction.

Third, I want to practice linguistic justice as classroom management. In our seminar discussion, a participant noted that many schooling norms assume “total silence and compliance” and then punish students whose discourse norms include dialogue and overlapping talk (E4). For CLD students, being marked as “disrespectful” can be less about intent and more about mismatch with dominant participation norms. For neurodivergent students, the same compliance norms can punish regulation strategies (talking while thinking, moving, blurting). A linguistically just classroom is not a chaotic classroom; it is a classroom where the norms of participation are taught explicitly, modeled with care, and designed for learning rather than control.

Finally, I want to use Talusan’s (2022) disability-conscious routines alongside DisCrit (Annamma et al., 2013) to audit my language: am I labeling a student, or am I describing a condition and a support plan? Nieto (2004) frames this as refusing deficit thinking—explaining struggle through student characteristics instead of through interactional and structural conditions. hooks (1994) frames it as engaged pedagogy: staying curious about the whole person underneath the behavior. In practice, that means I want to scaffold before I shame, narrate competence before I narrate deficit, and choose participation structures that make room for more than one way of being a learner.

Conclusion

I began this paper with a bias that I could easily have left unnamed: the habit of treating behavioral and communicative difference as a window into fixed student character. Practicum observation gave me the evidence I needed to interrupt that habit.

Across the observation records, I saw how quickly a student can be produced as a “problem” through adult interpretation—and how quickly that category can loosen when adults respond relationally. When a student was invited into a purposeful role, spoken to with patience, and treated as capable, participation became possible again (E1; E3).

The linguistic justice lens sharpened this insight for CLD students. If schools treat silence, speed, and standardized speech as the only legitimate way to learn, then difference becomes punishable. The point is not to romanticize disruption or deny that classrooms need structure. The point is to locate the work where it belongs: in the interaction between the student and the conditions we create.

Going forward, my commitment is to treat that interpretive pause as pedagogy: a deliberate interruption of the institutional reflex to locate difficulty inside the student rather than inside the conditions the student is navigating. DisCrit (Annamma et al., 2013) reminds me that this reflex has a history and a pattern. Refusing it, one classroom moment at a time, is the work.

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